

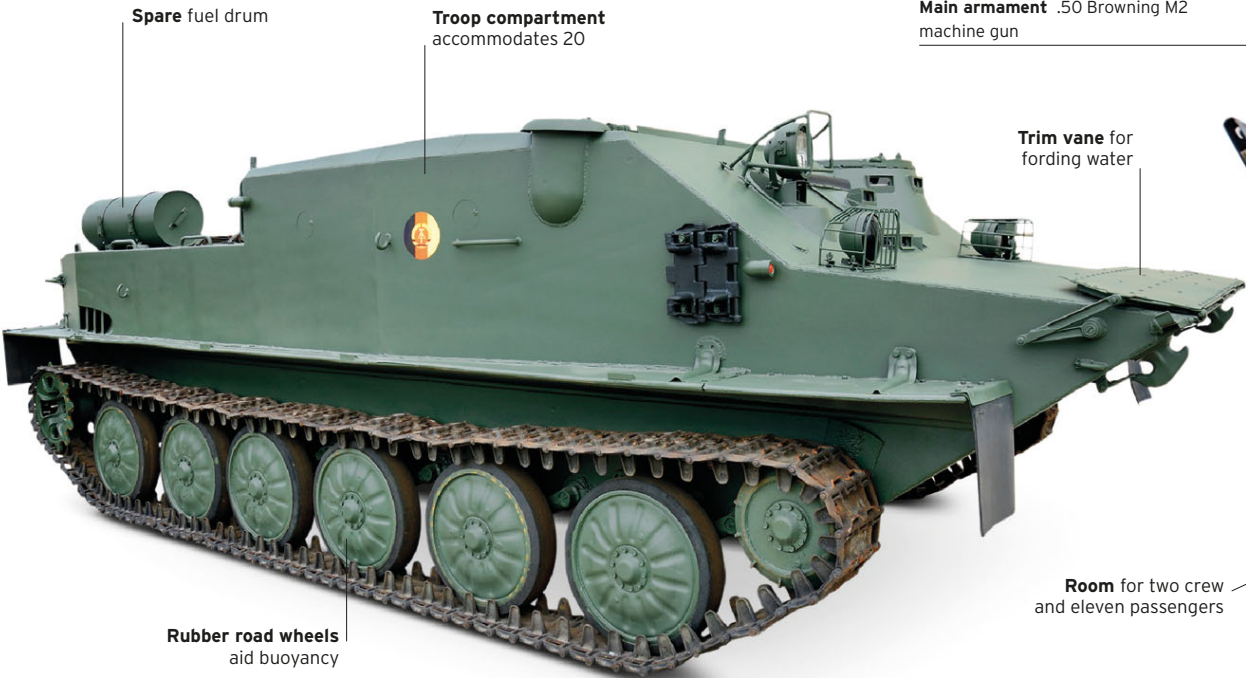
Tracked Armored Personnel Carriers

A fully tracked, fully armored vehicle that could carry infantry into battle alongside tanks has been sought since the latter's invention, and indeed the first, the Mark IX (see p.32), was ready in late 1918. It was not until the 1950s, however, that they began to become widespread. Many early designs resembled boxes on tracks, having only light armor and firepower that rarely extended beyond a machine gun. Few had the mobility to keep up with tanks over rough terrain.



△ M75
Date 1952 Country USA
Weight 20.7 tons (18.8 tonnes)
Engine Continental AO-895-4 gasoline, 295 hp
Main armament .50 Browning M2 machine gun

The M75 could carry a standard US infantry squad of 11 men, who accessed the vehicle through double doors at the rear. Its running gear was based on the M41 light tank, but overall it was too heavy, tall, and expensive, and its production ended after 1,729 had been built. Belgium was gifted 600, which they operated until the 1980s.



△ BTR-50P
Date 1954 Country Soviet Union
Weight 15.7 tons (14.2 tonnes)
Engine Model V-6 diesel, 240 hp
Main armament 7.62 mm SGMB machine gun

The BTR-50P was based on the PT-76 light tank and shared its parent's amphibious capability. Originally open-topped, it could carry 20 infantrymen, who climbed in and out over the sides. Early vehicles also had ramps to allow a towed artillery piece to be carried on the engine deck. A wide range of variants were used by dozens of nations.



△ M59
Date 1954 Country USA
Weight 21.3 tons (19.3 tonnes)
Engine 2 x General Motors Model 302 gasoline, 127 hp each
Main armament .50 Browning M2 machine gun

The lighter, lower, and cheaper replacement for the M75, the M59 added amphibious capability but was less well armored. Infantrymen now used a ramp to access the vehicle, which, along with folding seats, made it a more useful cargo carrier. Its twin engines were considered unreliable, and by the mid-1960s it was being retired.



△ AMX VCI
Date 1957 Country France
Weight 16.6 tons (15 tonnes)
Engine Detroit Diesel 6V-53T diesel, 280 hp
Main armament .50 Browning M2 machine gun

The VCI chassis was based on the AMX-13 tank. Ten infantrymen entered through the two rear doors; firing ports were mounted on each of these and the hull. The machine gun was replaced with a 20mm cannon on some vehicles. Variants included a radar carrier, engineer vehicle, mortar carrier, and ambulance.